

1

Maria Crahan arrived at her workplace, a DanariTek cybernetic implant factory, to the sight of a police hovercar parked up front and the sounds of an approaching ambulance, its sirens piercing the air and turning the otherwise serene morning atmosphere into something else entirely. It was rare to see the police and medical crew here at the same time, so she couldn't help but wonder what had happened here to warrant their simultaneous presence. Had someone been attacked? Killed? Was there a riot breaking out? Were people injured? She ran every possible scenario in her mind before covering her ears – the blaring of the ambulance sirens was starting to hurt them – and running inside.

And when she made it indoors, the image given to her by the brewing chaos was none the clearer. People – her coworkers – ran around and screamed in panic. The noise in the lounge was deafening. Maria kept her ears covered as she proceeded further inward, eventually deciding to stop one of her coworkers to ask what was going on.

The person she stopped was Deren Falk, cybersurgeon, son of Steve Falk – also a DanariTek cybersurgeon – and her mentor back when she'd just been hired. “What the hell

happened here?!” she yelled to Deren, barely able to hear herself from the commotion.

“Enez was stabbed”, Deren yelled a panicked response. “Police came to interrogate her about something, she walked out to Steve stabbing her, and now Steve has a bullet in his head.”

“Steve?!” Maria hollered in disbelief. Steve had always seemed a decent guy to her, not mentally unstable in any way. Certainly not enough to just stab a coworker unprompted. She thought she had known him long enough to form a thorough image of him, but as it now turned out... “Why did he attack Enez?”

“Fuck if I know. I never thought I’d see him doing that to anyone, let alone here.” And Maria had every reason to believe Deren’s assessment – after all, he was Steve’s son. He if anyone knew his father better than anyone else at the factory.

Maria pulled Deren in for a hug as a way to offer her condolences. Steve might have committed a horrendous breaking of character in her mind, but that didn’t change her feeling the need to comfort a coworker – a friend – after losing his only living parent. “I’ll be okay”, Deren assured Maria in a half-whisper.

“I know. You’re strong”, Maria replied. “What about Enez? She okay?”

“She’s alive.”

“I heard the ambulance arriving just now. Was it you who alerted it?”

“No, I think the police officers did.”

Maria merely nodded in response. Enez would be fine in the medics’ care. In a way, Maria felt bad for her – Enez wasn’t one for making friends in the workplace, so nobody dared to approach her, but her coworkers still cared about her. Well, some of them cared. And Maria was one of them, that much she could admit.

She wanted to run to Enez and look over her while they waited for the medics to come in, but she trusted the police would do so in her stead. Besides, she had another objective in mind, and for that, she needed to get to her office. In that moment, a commanding baritone voice echoed through the chaotic lounge: “Calm down and make way, people! We have medics coming in.”

Maria threw her gaze to the direction the voice had come from for a moment, then quickly turned back to Deren. “I got to get to my office. Talk to you later, yeah?”

“Yeah. Absolutely.”

“Sorry about Steve. Again.”

“Thanks. I’ll manage, though.”

Maria gave Deren a parting pat on the shoulder and started making a dash for her office, but not before stopping at the open doorway where Steve Falk lay with a bullet in his head. Looking at his lifeless body, slowly bleeding out onto the plastic flooring, made her want to puke, but she managed to hold it back somehow. “Rest in peace, Steve”, she whispered to the body, almost forgetting herself there until one of the police

officers gave her a commanding pat on the shoulder and said to her: “Move along. Let the medics in.” A command that some people were still taking their time obeying.

Maria, on the other hand, was nothing if not obedient. “Right. Sorry”, she muttered carefully in response and continued strolling towards her office with a casualness that betrayed her true feelings about what she’d seen and heard happen here today. Her only hope was that this wouldn’t become a common occurrence.

She made it to the door of her office, digging up her employee badge and tapping it against the scanner. The scanner beeped, the door slid open, and the office welcomed her with a calming odor courtesy of the lilacs she’d bought on her vacation in Central Europe. The flower shop she had stumbled upon was one of the few that still had real flowers – most sold synthetic flowers because real ones were rare to find these days, and the price definitely reflected that. The lilacs sat in a very plain but functional vase on Maria’s desk, right next to her holocomp. She closed her eyes as she entered the office and took a deep whiff of the floral aroma, then let out a relaxed exhale and sat down at her desk.

First order of business: see if there’s any mention of Yoshiro Busujima’s murder on the Net. Maria had been on a call with a police officer earlier in the morning where she’d been informed that her father had been killed. On prison ground the day he was supposed to walk out, no less. How had that been possible? The prisons of Neo-Tokyo were supposed to be some

of the most secure in the world. She danced her fingers across the holographic keyboard of the computer as she typed in her Net search query: “Yoshiro Busujima murder”. No results. Evidently the news hadn’t reached the press yet, or if it had, they’d deemed it wasn’t worth reporting on. After all, Yoshiro was a nobody compared to another figure that had died recently – Yosuke Harashima, coincidentally the CEO of the company Maria worked for, among many others. She’d heard the news on her way to work. Officially, his cause of death was undisclosed, but police involvement suggested a murder. Maybe that’s why they had come here to interrogate Enez.

But why Enez specifically? What did she have to do with Harashima’s death? Maria didn’t pretend to know the first thing about it, but she was worried about Enez either way. She hoped she wouldn’t get into trouble.

“Now you show up”, came an irritated voice from Maria’s doorway. She looked up from her holocomp and was greeted by the sight of her boss, Martin Stokes. An unpleasant man in every way possible, but Maria didn’t dare say that to his face, lest she get fired.

“Sorry I missed the party”, Maria replied sarcastically. “Anything you want me for?”

“Not right now. Just wanted to say hi. Keep your comm line open, though.”

“Will do”, Maria replied with a raised thumb.

Upon hearing Maria’s affirmative, Martin left without another word, leaving her to her own devices. When she was

sure no one else was coming in to interrupt her, she punched in another Net search query: “Yosuke Harashima death”. The news was all over the Net. A million news articles, posts of varying length thanking him for what he gave to the world, an equal number of posts effectively saying “good riddance”... and somehow only a single mention of an investigation looking into his death. If the information reached one news network, one would think it’d reach all the rest. But that wasn’t the case here. It was as if the police didn’t want the larger public to know about the investigation. Maria couldn’t help but wonder why.

Either way, Harashima wasn’t her primary concern. It was her father, Yoshiro Busujima. She wanted to know who had killed him, why, how. And if no one else was going to look into it, she’d have to do it herself.

2

Josh Heynes and Jenn Walters walked through the double doors that constituted the main entrance to the Office of Legal and Military Operations, the headquarters of the Neo-Tokyo police force among other things, wordlessly and side by side like they had so many times over the years. The way they performed their entrance felt like a carefully choreographed routine at this point. Every muscle movement, every breath, every little noise down to the millisecond, including the mechanical whine of the doors as they parted to let them in.

A casual observer might have mistaken them for a couple that also happened to be colleagues, but that couldn't be further from the truth. Never mind the 15-year age gap – that wasn't the big issue anyway – the real obstacle was the fact that Josh was married. And he preferred to stay faithful. If they were both single, there was a chance they'd be romantically involved at this point. But they knew not to tread where they shouldn't.

"So what do you make of Miss Harady's testimony?" Josh inquired of Jenn as the two of them walked down the hallway towards the main elevator.

"Which part of it?" Jenn asked in response.

"The last part. Right before she got stabbed."

Jenn sighed heavily before replying, weighing what she'd heard internally. "Mixed feelings. If what she said about Harashima is true, then everything we've known about him was nothing but a carefully crafted illusion. A facade to hide his true nature from the world." She paused for another sigh, then continued: "I'm concerned about her safety as well going forward. There's no telling if she's going to be attacked again and, if she is, where and by whom."

"I'm with you there", Josh muttered heavily. "We should put her under the witness protection program. She's an important piece of the puzzle with the dirt she has on Harashima."

"Yeah", came a sharp but concerned reply from Jenn. In that moment, they came up to the main elevator, and Jenn hovered her hand over the Call button. They waited for the elevator to reach the ground floor and entered it, and Josh hit the button for the 21st floor, where the police force's offices were situated.

"Remember", Jenn said to Josh in her 'friendly reminder' voice as they began ascending, "lead the meeting in Jangl. Just for Shinji's sake." A necessary reminder, given that consideration for his non-English-speaking colleagues was a skill Josh had to admit he was still brushing up on, even after ten years of working with Shinji.

"I know", Josh replied with a mix of thankfulness and frustration at Jenn stating the obvious.

Barely a minute passed between the elevator beginning its ascent and the pair reaching their floor. They exited into the main hall of the police offices and began their trek towards the one where the rest of Josh's team was already waiting, agreeing to speak to each other no more. Not without the full team present and accounted for.

They entered a medium-sized conference room way in the back, greeted by the sight of three other police officers that had been assigned to the Harashima case. Shinji Furuki, Devin Nichols and Goro Satou. Out of the five of them, Shinji was the only one that didn't speak English, so Josh would have to carry out the meeting in Jangl – a creole that mixed English and Japanese, with hints of Chinese. For Shinji's sake, as Jenn had said.

"Alright, crew", he addressed the room as he closed the door. Josh had been in the police force the longest out of everyone in the room, so he'd naturally been assigned as the lead investigator on the Harashima case and held the kind of authority the rest of the officers didn't. They saluted him accordingly, Jenn included. Having received the team's greetings, Josh continued: "Got some more pieces to the Harashima puzzle. Bust out your notepads."

Nobody made a move. They didn't have to. Josh's order in the moment was purely metaphorical.

"Officer Walters", he addressed Jenn and guided her to paste the new information they had onto the holographic whiteboard, breaking from the Jangl for that single line. He

figured Shinji wouldn't be offended over him switching to English for so much. He took a quick look at Shinji and scanned his facial expression just to make sure. No visible offense taken on Shinji's part, far as he could tell.

Jenn performed a series of motions in front of the whiteboard, and mere seconds later, a couple more images and some more text – mostly from Enez Harady's testimony file – had appeared on it.

"Latest addition", Josh addressed the room while pointing to the image of Miss Harady, "Enez Harady. Cybernetics engineer at DanariTek. Assigned chief of the team that produced Harashima's cybernetic penis. Got stabbed by a coworker right as she walked out."

"Fatally?" inquired Devin.

"Not very", Jenn replied. "Likelihood of survival is 92% according to the medics."

"So what's the rest of her deal?" Shinji then asked.

Josh proceeded to explain, a subtle sense of concern coloring his tone: "She's got dirt on Harashima. Very serious allegations that would destroy everything the guy built. Got good reason to suspect that's why she got stabbed too. Assailant likely eavesdropped and wanted to silence her, prevent her info from going public."

"So put her under witness protection?" asked Goro. "Is that the plan?"

"Yeah", Jenn shot a sharp reply. "She's already too important to the case to lose."

“And the other new face?” came a follow-up inquiry from Shinji. Josh had somehow already forgotten there *was* another new face – he had to turn his eyes to the whiteboard for a second to remind himself. When it came to him, he turned his gaze back to the others and continued: “Steve Falk. The stabber.”

“Could we bring him in for questioning?” Devin asked.

Josh inhaled a little deeper and sharper, slightly startled by Devin’s inquiry. “He’s, uhh... unavailable for testimony”, he confessed.

“Overly itchy trigger finger again?” came an accusatory inquiry from Goro. Josh merely nodded in response, a tangible sense of regret to the motion. The rest of the room sighed collectively.

“We’re going to have to report you to the CEO at this rate, Josh”, Shinji said to Josh like a disappointed father. “Has your eyesight gotten so bad that you can no longer tell the difference between a head and a knee?” He wanted to sound sarcastic, but Josh had eliminated enough key pieces to prior investigations that he no longer had the energy to muster the tone. Had made enough of these mistakes for the other officers to suspect that they hadn’t been entirely accidental for a while. But Josh was impulsive – arguably a little too much so to be a police officer. He just wasn’t willing to admit that to himself.

“Let’s keep my eyesight out of this meeting, alright?” Josh hollered an irritated response, then continued in an attempt to steer the conversation back to the development of the investi-

gation: “Anyway. New priority is to get Miss Harady into the witness protection program ASAP. We’ll continue investigating once we know she’s safe.” With a nod and a subtle wave of his hand, he then muttered: “Dismissed.”

And thus, the meeting came to a close, and the officers left the conference room.

Except for Jenn. She stood beside Josh for a moment longer, waited for the others to leave, and when the two of them were alone again, she laid a gentle hand on Josh’s shoulder and said to him: “Don’t let Shinji get under your skin. I know it hurts, but he just cares about you. Like we all do.”

Josh sighed repentantly. He knew Jenn was right. He knew Shinji was just making sure he wouldn’t repeat his past mistakes. And yet he had, too many times to count. Can’t teach an old dog new tricks, he supposed.

“Thanks, Jenn”, he muttered and clasped a hand over hers, reinforcing his gratefulness for her support. A moment later, both of their hands fell off his shoulder in a synchronized motion.

“Want me to go check on our stabbing victim?” Jenn then asked Josh.

“Sure”, Josh replied neutrally, neither ordering nor stopping her. “If you need me, I’ll be in my office.”

“Roger”, Jenn muttered affirmatively and walked out of the conference room, with Josh following and heading towards his own office not long afterwards.

3

Jenn walked through the labyrinthine corridors of the infirmary floor with a hop to her step that betrayed her concern for the latest witness in the Harashima case. There was no knowing the level of risk Miss Harady had put herself in by telling the police what she knew about Yosuke Harashima. If a coworker had stabbed her right as she walked out of the interrogation in an attempt to silence her, what was the likelihood of it happening again? Jenn wasn't sure, but she prayed it would end up being an isolated incident. That the only person that wanted her dead had been eliminated, courtesy of Josh's overly itchy trigger finger.

She continued forward, greeting staff as she passed them by, and eventually came up to the reception desk. "Hi", she hollered to the young man behind the counter, who responded with equal cheer. "Came by to check on Enez Harady. Which room is she in?"

"That'd be room 265", the man replied. His voice was oddly soothing. Looked handsome as well, Jenn thought to herself. She didn't come by here often, so she was only so familiar with most of the building's medical staff. She wondered if this dashing fellow was one of the medics or only

worked reception – it wasn't unusual for some medics to occasionally have to work reception, that much she did know. "265?" she repeated, and the man gave her a confirmatory nod. "Great. Thanks", she thanked the man and turned towards the hallway where room 265 would be.

On her way, she saw a figure in the distance that she didn't expect to run into on the infirmary floor, walking towards her. The figure spoke first as he recognized her. "Ah. Hi, Jenn."

"Hey, Koji."

Koji Hodo, another police officer. Second longest-serving in the Neo-Tokyo force right after Josh. "Didn't expect to see you here", Jenn hollered to Koji in a surprised tone.

"Just taking a little walk", Koji replied. "Felt like I couldn't breathe up there. Air's so much better on this floor. Good for the joints, you know."

"Yeah. Proper air conditioning works wonders, eh?"

"It really does." Koji threw his arms skyward in a stretching motion so as to demonstrate. "So anyway, what are you doing down here?"

"Checking in on a witness. Got stabbed, should be down here somewhere."

"The DanariTek girl?"

"Yeah. How'd you know?"

"Shinji filled me in on her. I know I'm not assigned to the Harashima case, but I was curious."

"Uh-huh." It wasn't uncommon for the police to casually talk about ongoing cases, even when two officers were assigned

to completely different ones, but she'd always figured Shinji was the type to *not* partake in such conversation. It wasn't against protocol, though, so she didn't care. Much.

"Anyway, catch you later", she said in farewell to Koji and continued her trek towards room 265.

"Sure", Koji hollered in response behind her. "See ya."

A stinging sensation woke Enez up from her slumber. She wasn't sure how long she'd been out for, nor where she was now. Not the DanariTek facility, that much she *was* sure of. No room in there looked as sterile as this one. Or had beds, let alone ones that felt this uncomfortable. If she didn't know any better, she would've come to the conclusion that she was in a torture chamber just based off that impression.

The color scheme of her surroundings told her that she'd been wheeled to an infirmary of some kind. Then she remembered the stinging sensation that'd jolted her awake, remembered something thin and sharp embedding into her stomach, remembered passing out with it still inserted.

She looked down to where the "weapon" had been and found that it'd been removed and replaced with bandages. Then, a voice echoed from her right side: "Welcome back."

Looking to the direction of the voice, Enez was greeted by an oddly familiar face, though one she'd only seen once prior. It took her a few seconds to place it – it was one of the

police officers that'd come by DanariTek to interrogate her. The one that'd called the medics to her rescue. Enez's expression remained a stony mask of indifference as she stared at the woman.

"Jenn Walters", she reintroduced herself. "Wanted to come by and check in on you. Feeling okay?"

Enez tried to produce a "Yeah" in response, but her throat was so dry it turned her attempt to speak into a raspy cough. Jenn grabbed a glass of water from a nearby desk and handed it to her, then assisted her in sitting up so she could actually gulp it down.

Enez emptied the glass in one swift motion and, feeling reinvigorated and like she could speak again, said afterwards: "Thanks. I really needed that."

"Least I can do", Jenn replied empathically.

"You called the medics, right?"

"That I did. Couldn't just leave you to bleed to death after what you told us."

The interrogation. It was coming back to Enez. What she told the cops... about Harashima. "What I..." she began in a raspy half-whisper, looking down at herself again. The memories of the events that had landed her here were flooding back to her. She turned her gaze back to Jenn and asked her, as if to confirm her own theory: "Did I spill too much?"

"What do you mean?" Jenn asked in response.

"About Harashima", Enez clarified. "That's why I got stabbed, right? Because I know stuff that'd bring his whole

empire down.” She placed a hand over her face in something akin to embarrassment, laying back down on the bed, uncomfortable as its AluPlast surface felt, and cursed herself: “God, I’m fucking stupid. I should’ve just kept my mouth shut. Now all of my coworkers want me silenced. *Dead.*”

“Hey”, Jenn interjected in an attempt to soothe Enez, placing a hand on her shoulder. “You did what felt right at the time. That’s the important thing.” She let out a concerned but somehow reassuring sigh before continuing. “As for your coworkers, I can’t assure you one way or the other, but we’ll protect you. With how much you know, you’re too important to the case to lose.”

“I know that’s supposed to put me at ease, but it’s kinda doing the opposite”, Enez admitted, only marginally calmer.

Jenn smiled in amusement and let out an accompanying sharp exhale through her nose, then asked Enez: “So what *would* put you at ease?”

Enez shifted on the bed slightly, trying to assume a position that would make her feel more comfortable. More relaxed. “A motherly hug, kiss on the cheek, bedtime story... and a shot of the shittiest whiskey you have.”

Jenn chuckled. “Can’t bring alcohol to the workplace, I’m afraid”, she said with a hint of regret. “Not a mother either, but a hug I can do.”

Enez turned a slightly inquisitive gaze to Jenn, scanning her expression for the smallest hint of humor. She didn’t find

any. Jenn was serious in her offer. “That’ll have to do, I guess”, Enez responded with a subtle sarcastic flair.

Jenn helped her up again and wrapped her arms around her in the most comforting hug she had ever felt, and Enez responded to the hug with equal affection.

A lonely tear rolled down Enez’s cheek as the ladies released their grips from each other. She looked down as she said with a grateful melodiousness: “Didn’t realize how much I actually needed that.”

“Glad I could help”, Jenn replied affectionately. Then she continued with a more pragmatic tone: “And like I said, you’ll be safe with us. We’ll put you into our witness protection program. That way, you’ll at least be less likely to get in harm’s way.”

“Less likely?” Enez repeated inquisitively.

“That’s an unfortunate part of this line of work. No guarantees.”

“Well, ‘less likely’ is better than ‘sure to be dead within the week’”, Enez admitted, her voice still a little shaky from the earlier wave of emotion. “How soon can you get me in?”

“Take your time recovering first, then we’ll talk about it. You’re still—”

“Time is no longer a luxury I can afford”, Enez half-yelled, becoming more agitated by the spoken word. “There’s a fucking stabwound in my stomach. I’m lucky none of my vital organs were hit, but what if it happens again? The likelihood of the next hit being fatal has already increased tenfold. You’re

stupid if you think I'm waiting until I get better to fight for my own survival, no offense."

Jenn stared into her eyes. She hoped the officer would see the determination, the truth behind every word she'd spoken. She let out a long, contemplative exhale through her nose, then answered Enez calmly: "Okay. I'll talk to my colleagues ASAP. With enough luck, we can get you into the program by tomorrow."

"Much appreciated", Enez replied, a lot more calmly after Jenn's assurances.

"You should still rest, though", Jenn suggested. "Don't want to risk reopening the wound. It could do that if you move too much."

"I know. Doctor said the same thing."

"Good", Jenn replied, confident that Enez was smart enough to listen to the medical staff here. "I'll leave you in your doctor's care from here. See you again when I get the witness protection sorted out."

"Yeah."

"Alright. Rest well."

"Yes, mum", Enez hollered a sarcastic response to Jenn, who was already halfway to the infirmary room door. She lifted an arm and waved it, not sure if Jenn was there to see it, and shouted an unusually affectionate "Bye".

Jenn seemed a good cop to Enez. Not at all like what she thought to be the average type: cold, stoic, no empathy whatsoever, gun in hand 24/7 in case some slash-happy psycho

got a little too close. No, Jenn was the complete opposite of that. And Enez was delighted to know that cops like her existed. She hadn't been sure if they did up until now.

Anyway, time to rest up. For only God – if he existed – knew what was ahead of Enez.